

Hawk's Eye View

A useful contribution to the expert body of knowledge on India's nuclear option

By Raj Chengappa

The title of Bharat Karnad's book is rather bland for an issue that has been the subject of raging controversy. India's nuclear policy is something that isn't as yet set in stone. After India's civilian nuclear deal with the US, there was a need to understand how this could alter New Delhi's policy and work out the deviations in its trajectory. Also, to examine more closely the new strands that have emerged in the world, including the "nuclear zero" approach. Karnad had the opportunity to do so with his weighty book. Unfortunately, he keeps the discussion on the deal to the very end and when he does get to it, disappointingly, it is just a sum up of all the arguments put out, mainly the ones against it. With both his journalistic background and his eye for the big picture, Karnad could have looked ahead and come up with alternatives that could have helped in evolving policy.

All these shortcomings in no way detract from the value of the book and its contribution to the growing expert body of knowledge on India's nuclear policy. While the opening chapters set the world stage and look at India's nuclear past, the most interesting chapter for me was the one which deals with the maturing of the country's nuclear and missile capabilities. Karnad has dug deep and filled up the gaps about the development of India's nuclear option since the all important 1998 nuclear tests. His final chapter then juxtaposes it with the threats posed by China and Pakistan. By interviewing both the key players and strategists during the NDA regime, Karnad comes up with fresh and interesting material about the way India's nuclear plans have shaped up. It is apparent that Karnad is a nuclear hawk but one that is willing to argue his case in detail. There are some candid assessments which are bound to be controversial. For instance, Karnad quotes Jaswant Singh, the foreign minister in the NDA government, as saying about the then prime minister A.B. Vajpayee that "by instinct he is placatory" and "had from the beginning in his public stance been in support of disarmament... There was no bouncing off ideas with his confidantes... It (the testing moratorium) was an instinctive reaction. It shows up Vajpayee in bad light." But it's also obvious that Karnad does not have the same access with the UPA regime and so the thinking of its leaders and strategists as to their approach towards India's evolving nuclear doctrine is sorely lacking. That tends to date the book more to a policy of circa 2004 rather than 2009. ■



INDIA'S NUCLEAR POLICY
by BHARAT KARNAD
Pentagon Press
Price: Rs 795
Pages: 221

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